

5 Steps to run a club allocation

After-school clubs are an important part of school life, but first-come booking can create a stressful stampede. Clubstonbury is a free, fair and private alternative that works with the forms and spreadsheets your school already uses.

1. CREATE Create and share Send the form to every eligible family.	2. COLLECT Leave it open Two weeks is one useful timeframe.	3. ALLOCATE Run the allocation Export, check and set capacities.	4. MOP UP Do the mop-up Decide how to use waiting lists.	5. COMPLETE Done! Send invoices and file the allocation data.
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1. Set up the family survey

Google Forms and SurveyMonkey both export responses to CSV. Build one response per child with:

See an example: download the fake applications and capacities from clubstonbury.onrender.com/demo.

- the child's name and a parent contact field;
- first club choice** (required);
- second and third choices (optional); and
- an automatic submission timestamp.

Use the same club spelling in every choice question. Choose a response window that works for your school; two weeks is a useful example, not a requirement. Explain eligibility, the deadline and that submission time does not affect the on-time lottery.

Choice design: let families choose up to three clubs, but do not require all three choices. Ranking a genuine lower preference cannot reduce the chance of receiving a higher-ranked choice.

2. Export and check

When your chosen response window closes, stop responses and download the form results as CSV. Keep this original file in the school's protected storage.

- Remove duplicates and test submissions.
- Confirm each child is eligible for every chosen club.
- Resolve spelling variants before importing.
- Keep an untouched copy of the original export.

Clubstonbury does not decide eligibility and cannot know whether a form answer is factually correct.

3. Pseudonymise before allocation

Original survey

Name, contact, timestamp, choices

>

Private lookup

id, name
Keep at school

>

Lottery CSV

ID, timestamp, choices
No names

Create the random IDs

In Excel or Google Sheets, enter this in

A2

, then fill down:

= "kid_" & LOWER (DEC2HEX (RANDBETWEEN (0, 2147483647), 8))

Excel

Copy column A, then use Home > Paste > Values.

Google Sheets

Copy column A, then use Edit > Paste special > Values only.

The formulas recalculate, so freeze the IDs as values immediately. In a spare column, use =COUNTIF(\$A:\$A, A2) > 1 and confirm every row is FALSE; regenerate any duplicate. Make a separate two-column ID-to-name lookup and never upload that lookup to Clubstonbury.

Data protection note: IDs that the school can reconnect to names are pseudonymous, not fully anonymous. The lookup and lottery files remain personal data in the school's hands. Store them separately, limit access and follow the school's retention policy.

From CSV to offers

Seed included in the ZIP filename

4. Make the two input files

Applications: exact headings

```
id,timestamp,choice_1,choice_2,choice_3
kid_7f3a91c2,2026-09-01T09:30:00Z,Drama,Coding,Art
kid_3d8b104e,2026-09-02T13:14:00Z,Football,Drama,
```

id must be unique. First choice is required; second and third are optional but must be contiguous.

Capacities: one row per club

```
club,capacity
Drama,16
Coding,12
Art,10
Football,20
```

Capacity is the total number of places available and may be zero. Names must match the application choices, ignoring letter case.

5. Run the allocation

- 1 **Open Allocate places.** Select the pseudonymous applications CSV.
- 2 **Read validation messages.** Fix blocking errors; investigate every warning.
- 3 **Load capacities.** Upload the capacity CSV, paste values or enter them manually.
- 4 **Review totals.** Check child count, capacity and each club row.
- 5 **Run the lottery.** Check allocations, unallocated children and waiting lists.
- 6 **Download the ZIP.** Its timestamped filename includes the seed. Store it securely.

Reproducibility: the ZIP filename contains the seed, and its manifest records the capacities, algorithm version and a source-file hash. If a result is challenged, use the retained inputs and that seed to rerun the allocation and compare the output.

6. Join names back in, securely

allocations.csv
id, allocated_1...

+

private lookup
id, name

Open both in the school's approved spreadsheet tool. Match each allocation ID to the lookup ID, then add the child's name locally. For Excel or Google Sheets, with the result ID in A2 and the lookup ID/name in columns A/B:

```
=XLOOKUP(A2, Mapping!A:A, Mapping!B:B, "Missing ID")
```

Check that no row says "Missing ID", that every expected child appears once, and that the joined row retains the correct opaque ID. Never upload the joined file to Clubstonbury.

7. Offers, returns and mop-up

If a place is declined, the downloaded waiting list provides Clubstonbury's reproducible order for that club. The school decides how to use the list and is responsible for every subsequent offer. In the published workflow, remaining places move to **first-come, first-served** mop-up after the school has finished with the original waiting list.

Final administrator check

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Eligibility checked | ☐ Capacities confirmed |
| ☐ IDs unique | ☐ Warnings reviewed |
| ☐ Seed recorded | ☐ Results spot-checked |
| ☐ ZIP stored securely | ☐ Retention date set |

Responsibility: use Clubstonbury at your own risk. The school or administrator is fully responsible for input accuracy, legal compliance, checking the results and every offer made from them.